

Reading the Cap as the Curve

Self-Reported Hardship Against the Pantry's Fortnightly Cap

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Background

The Living Dashboard reads fortnightly pantry-visit counts as a leading indicator of financial hardship for discretionary-support triage. The pantry itself rations visits to one per fortnight — whether the count tracks need, or just the ration's shape, is untested.

Research questions

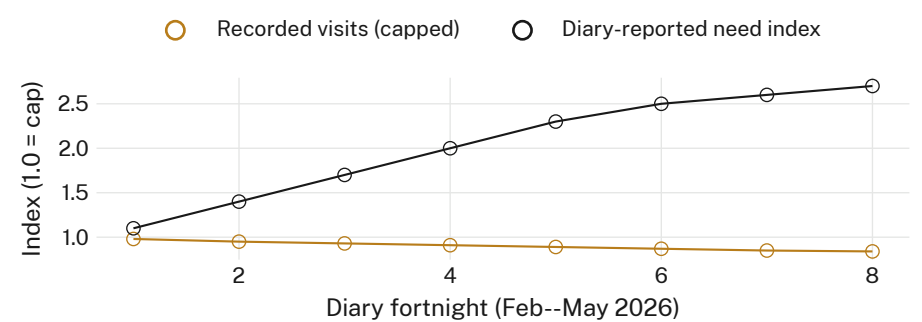
- Do recorded visit counts approximate self-reported hardship independent of the fortnightly cap?
- Does diary-reported need keep accruing once a participant's cap binds?
- Is the recorded/diary gap patterned by how quickly a participant exhausts their allocation?

Approach

- $n = 64$ pantry users · confidential fortnightly need diary, uncapped · matched to the admin visit log · 8 fortnights (Feb–May 2026)
- Semi-structured exit interviews, subsample $n = 18$, on what counted as a “visit” once capped
- Diary-need index vs recorded-visit series compared by cross-lagged correlation; cap-bound fortnights modelled as right-censored, not missing

Findings

Diary-reported need kept rising after the recorded-visit series flattened at the cap: across 8 fortnights the diary index climbed 2.5×, while recorded visits held within 0.84–0.98 of one per fortnight ($r = 0.34$, $n = 64$). Divergence was sharpest among participants who exhausted their fortnightly allocation within its first two days.



Diary-reported need index rose from 1.1 to 2.7 (2.5×) across 8 diary fortnights (Feb–May 2026, $n = 64$) while recorded visits per participant held within 0.84–0.98 of the one-visit cap; the two series correlate at $r = 0.34$.

Discussion & conclusions

Recorded visits behave as a rationed count once the fortnightly cap binds, not a continuous hardship trace. Concordance is weakest exactly where discretionary-support triage depends on it most — among participants who exhaust the ration earliest. Exit interviews describe a “visit” as a resupply event, not a report of the fortnight's need. Next: pilot a confidential, uncapped self-report channel alongside the existing visit log, decoupled from ration eligibility.

References

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We thank the pantry's volunteers and diary participants for their time.

Diary responses de-identified before linkage; participation did not alter ration eligibility.

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